Richer Hymn Harmony

Hear secondary dominants, guide chromatic notes and plan changes of key.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

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2. Guide sevenths and leading notes
3. A purposeful chromatic bass
4. Make a clear change of key
5. Reharmonize with restraint
6. Eternal Father: chromatic destinations
7. Just As I Am: harmony and arrival
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1. Use a dominant that points beyond home

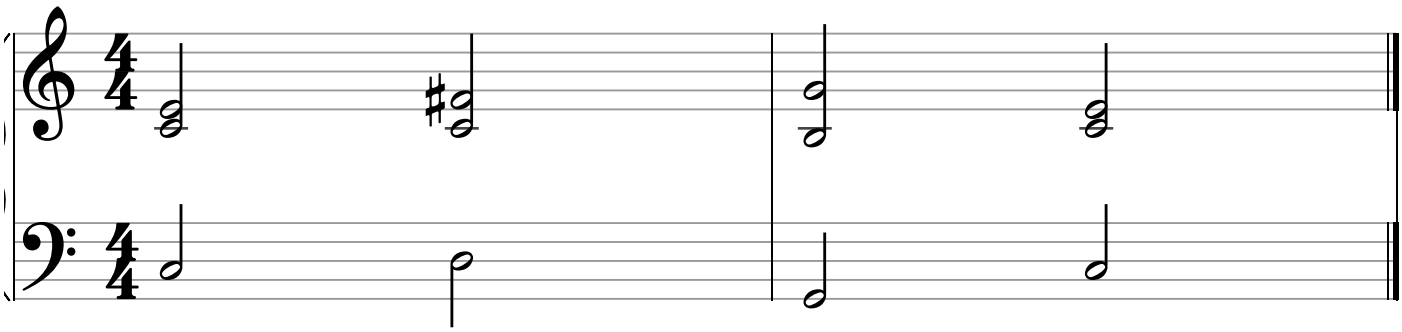
Hear V of V lead to the dominant.

Use a dominant that points beyond home

In C major, D7 contains F-sharp and points toward G. This is V of V: a temporary dominant directed at the dominant chord. F-sharp usually rises to G and the seventh C often falls to B. An accidental should have a purpose. Compare C-D7-G-C with C-Dm-G-C and listen to the different strength of the pull toward G.

Practise · V of V in C

Hear F-sharp rise to G and C fall to B.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · V of V in G

A7 leads to D: C-sharp resolves upward and G downward.

> **Review**
>
> In C major, where does D7 most directly point?
>
> **Answer:** G D7 is the dominant of G, which is the dominant in C.

Practise independently

Find a chromatic note in Melita and look at the following harmony. Name the destination before calling every accidental a modulation.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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2. Guide sevenths and leading notes
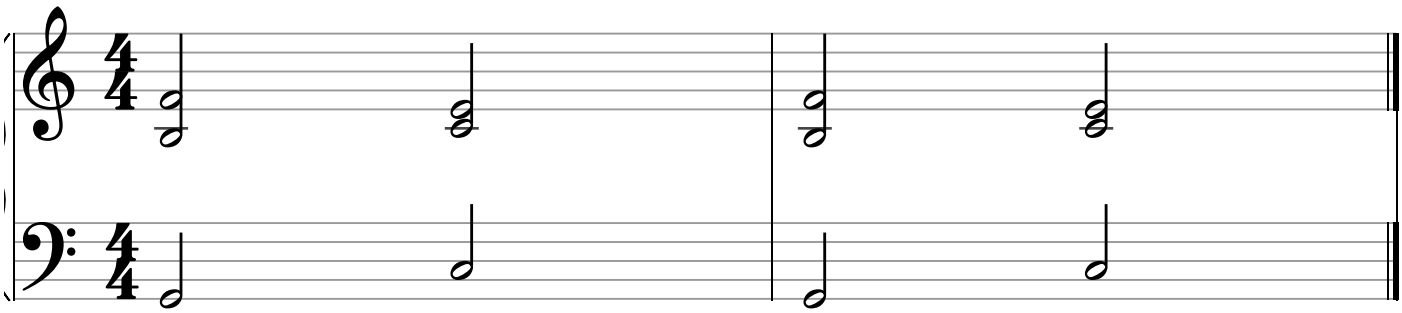
Let tendency tones resolve within clear voice leading.

Guide sevenths and leading notes

A seventh chord is more than a shape. Follow the seventh downward by step where the phrase calls for a conventional resolution, and follow the leading note toward its destination. Keep common tones where useful and avoid making every voice jump in parallel. These are listening guides for this style, not a rule that every hymn must resolve identically.

Practise · G7 resolves to C

Track the right-hand F-E and B-C motions.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A chain of destinations

D7-G7-C: hear one resolution prepare the next.

Practise independently

Play each inner line separately and sing its resolution. In the complete phrase, make the dissonance audible without accenting it harshly.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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3. A purposeful chromatic bass
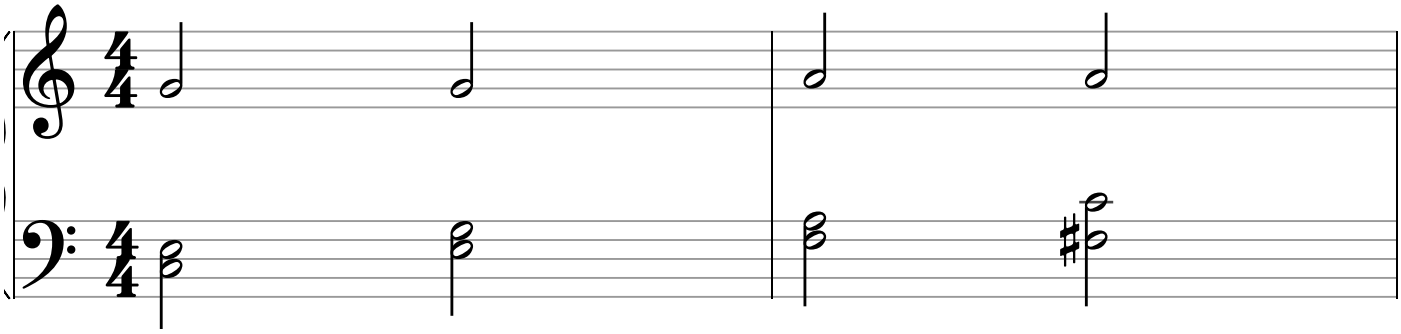
Connect harmonies without changing the melody arbitrarily.

A purposeful chromatic bass

A passing bass can connect two stable harmonies. In the model C-C/E-F-F-sharp diminished-G, the bass rises C-E-F-F-sharp-G and the diminished chord leads by small motions. Check that the melody fits each sonority; a chord that sounds attractive alone may clash with a held tune note. First understand the plain harmony, then change only one place.

Practise · Passing diminished colour

Hear F-sharp-A-C lead into G-B-D.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A descending line

Keep the top line steady over C-B-A-G.

Practise independently

Try one passing harmony in a familiar hymn offline. Sing the melody over it, then remove it. Keep the version that supports the phrase rather than the version with the most chords.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

4. Make a clear change of key

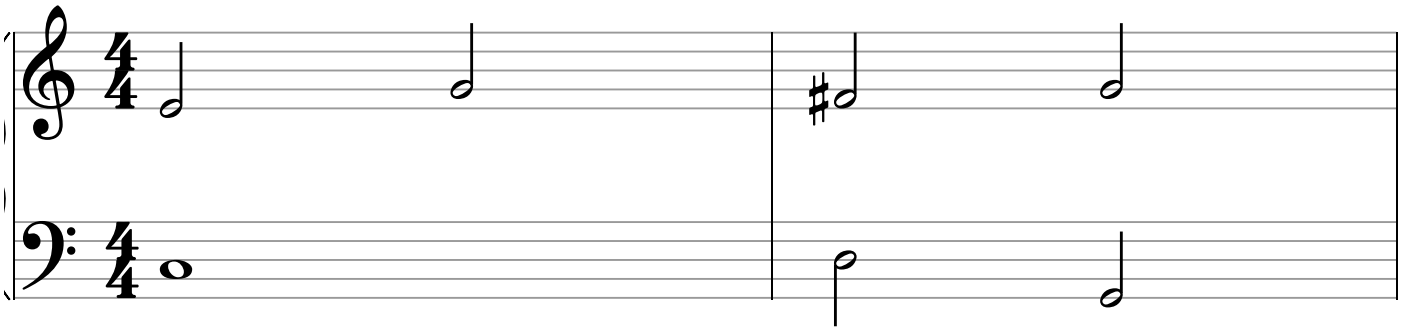
Prepare, confirm and settle into a new tonal home.

Make a clear change of key

A modulation establishes a new key; a single secondary dominant may only colour a moment. To move from C to G, a D7-G cadence can confirm the destination. Hear F-sharp as the new leading note, prepare a clear arrival, and continue a phrase in G so the listener recognizes a new home. For a singer, choose the destination for a comfortable vocal range and announce the plan before rehearsal.

Practise · C to G through D7

Hear the first C as home, then D7-G establish a new centre.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Stay in the new key

Confirm G with its own dominant, D7, before resting.

Practise independently

Play the first and last chords alone, then the complete model. Can you hear a change of home? Plan an offline whole-step transition only after the new key and singer entry are secure.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

5. Reharmonize with restraint
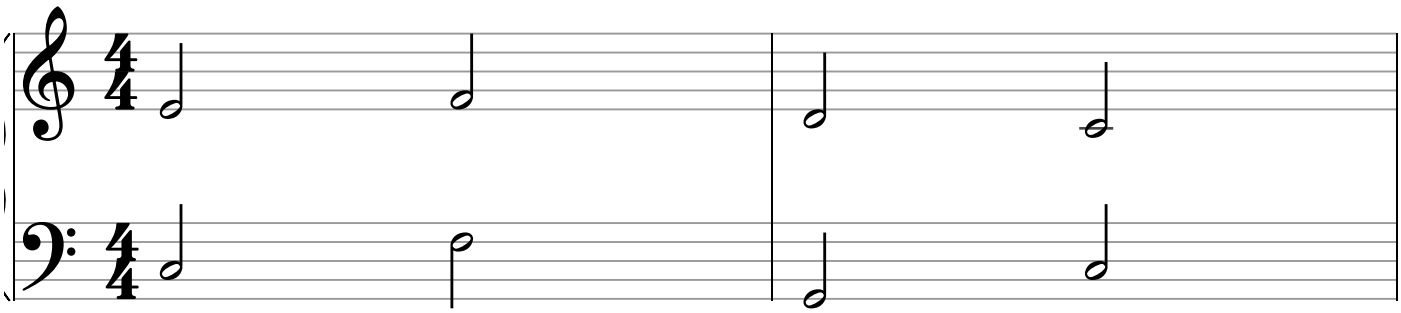
Choose substitutions that preserve melody, function and phrase.

Reharmonize with restraint

Start with the tune and bass. Mark the cadence and protect its destination. A vi chord can sometimes substitute for I, and a ii chord can prepare V, but the tune note must fit the new harmony or act as a deliberate passing tone. Try one substitution at a time. Keep a plain version ready for congregational singing; harmonic surprise should not make the entry or pulse uncertain.

Practise · One tune, two harmonic routes

Compare the same tune over a plain and a substitute progression.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Preserve the cadence

Keep B-F resolving to C-E while changing the preparation.

Practise independently

Choose four bars, label the plain chords and create one alternative offline. Sing the tune while playing only those chords. Explain why the replacement supports the line; then perform the printed reference when using the app check.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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6. Eternal Father: chromatic destinations

Read every accidental deliberately. Follow the bass and hear where each chromatic harmony leads before giving it extra weight.

Prepare the score
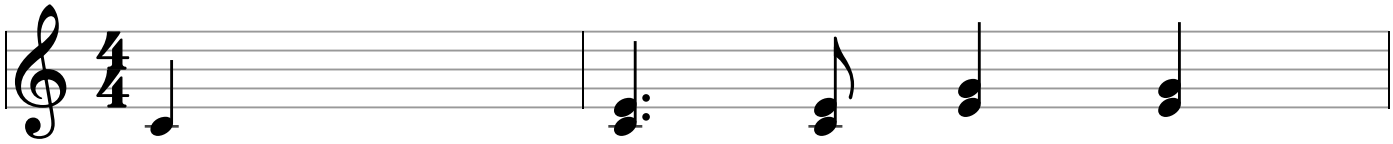
Read every accidental deliberately. Follow the bass and hear where each chromatic harmony leads before giving it extra weight.

This is a melody-led piano reduction: supporting tones change with the melody. Source inner voices may be moved by octaves or rearticulated; study their original rhythms using the source score.

Preview the key, meter, pickup and ending. Prepare a stable fingering before adding speed.

Practise · Right hand: voice the melody

Read the upper line first. Where there are two notes, keep the top voice clearer. Release unnecessary pressure.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand: shape the support

Count aloud and play softly. Move the arm between positions; do not hold a wide stretch.

Practise · Join the opening

Read every accidental deliberately. Follow the bass and hear where each chromatic harmony leads before giving it extra weight.

Practise · Eternal Father: chromatic destinations

Read every accidental deliberately. Follow the bass and hear where each chromatic harmony leads before giving it extra weight.

Make your own musical decision

Find a secondary-dominant motion in the linked source. Play its guiding tones alone and sing the resolution.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

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7. Just As I Am: harmony and arrival

Read the retained 6/4 meter calmly. Protect the cadence and hear the change of harmony underneath each longer melody note.

Prepare the score
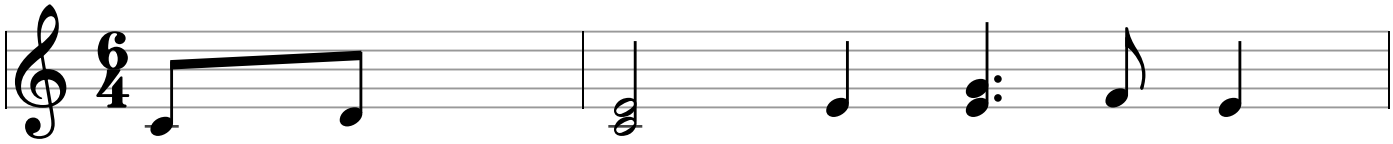
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This is a melody-led piano reduction: supporting tones change with the melody. Source inner voices may be moved by octaves or rearticulated; study their original rhythms using the source score.

Preview the key, meter, pickup and ending. Prepare a stable fingering before adding speed.

Practise · Right hand: voice the melody

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Opening example · 6/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand: shape the support

Count aloud and play softly. Move the arm between positions; do not hold a wide stretch.

Practise · Join the opening

Read the retained 6/4 meter calmly. Protect the cadence and hear the change of harmony underneath each longer melody note.

Practise · Just As I Am: harmony and arrival

Read the retained 6/4 meter calmly. Protect the cadence and hear the change of harmony underneath each longer melody note.

Make your own musical decision

Try one substitute preparation chord offline. Sing the tune over it and decide whether it supports the arrival.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

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8. Eternal Father in F: harmonic fluency

Carry the complete tune and chromatic harmony into F major. Prepare the new key, preserve the melodic contour and resolve the guiding tones clearly.

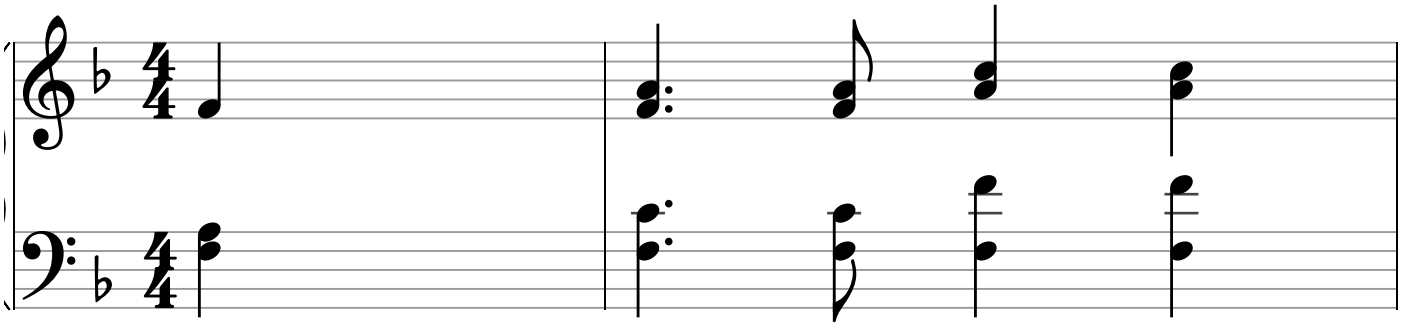
Prepare a complete performance

Carry the complete tune and chromatic harmony into F major. Prepare the new key, preserve the melodic contour and resolve the guiding tones clearly.

Choose a tempo at which you can finish comfortably. Mark three restart points, rehearse the opening and ending, then play without stopping. Afterwards assess pulse, clarity, phrasing, balance and recovery. Completion records a reference play-through, not a graded qualification or approval of an improvised arrangement.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Eternal Father, Strong to Save

Carry the complete tune and chromatic harmony into F major. Prepare the new key, preserve the melodic contour and resolve the guiding tones clearly.



Opening example · 4/4 · F · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Carry the complete tune and chromatic harmony into F major. Prepare the new key, preserve the melodic contour and resolve the guiding tones clearly.

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9. Just As I Am: harmonic direction

Hear the guiding tones and cadences in this 6/4 setting. Prepare each harmony, resolve tension clearly and keep the melody above the supporting notes.
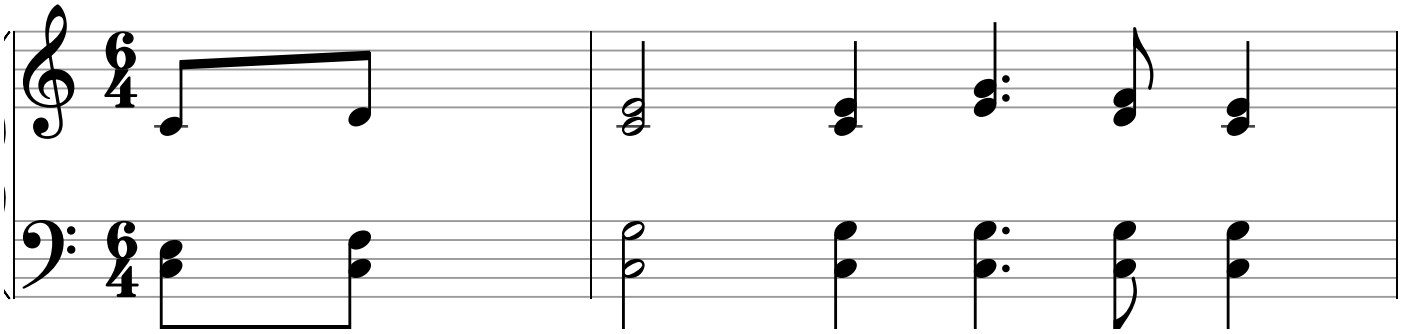
Prepare a complete performance

Hear the guiding tones and cadences in this 6/4 setting. Prepare each harmony, resolve tension clearly and keep the melody above the supporting notes.

Choose a tempo at which you can finish comfortably. Mark three restart points, rehearse the opening and ending, then play without stopping. Afterwards assess pulse, clarity, phrasing, balance and recovery. Completion records a reference play-through, not a graded qualification or approval of an improvised arrangement.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Just As I Am

Hear the guiding tones and cadences in this 6/4 setting. Prepare each harmony, resolve tension clearly and keep the melody above the supporting notes.



Opening example · 6/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Hear the guiding tones and cadences in this 6/4 setting. Prepare each harmony, resolve tension clearly and keep the melody above the supporting notes.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Hear V of V lead to the dominant.
- ☐ Let tendency tones resolve within clear voice leading.
- ☐ Connect harmonies without changing the melody arbitrarily.
- ☐ Prepare, confirm and settle into a new tonal home.
- ☐ Choose substitutions that preserve melody, function and phrase.
- ☐ Perform my chosen recital with its stated musical goals, clear voicing, reliable pulse, comfortable movement and a deliberate ending.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
